

STILL THERE

It began in 2006 in Amersfoort, the Netherlands, when 19-year-old Novak Djokovic claimed his first ATP Tour title. Nearly two decades later, he has joined a club occupied by only two other men in history, Jimmy Connors and Roger Federer, by reaching 100 career titles.

The journey to the landmark, however, was anything but linear. By the end of 2023, Djokovic had already amassed 98 titles, but the final stretch proved stubborn. As the tour's next generation grew bolder and Djokovic adjusted his schedule around longevity rather than volume, titles became harder to come by.

In 2024, he won just once. That solitary triumph, though, was an Olympic gold medal in Paris, the final major prize missing from his resume. After that, he endured nine tournaments without lifting a trophy, a run marked by close final defeats and unexpected early exits.

He arrived in Geneva two days after his 38th birthday as a late wildcard, ostensibly to fine-tune his game ahead of the French Open. There was also a personal pull. The lakeside city is home to close family, including relatives he was keen to visit after the recent birth of a child.

On the clay, sentiment gave way to steel. Djokovic outlasted Poland's Hubert Hurkacz in a demanding final, recovering from a set down to win 5-7, 7-6 (2), 7-6 (2) in just over three hours. It was not vintage dominance, but a familiar display of endurance, clarity under pressure, and refusal to yield.

"I'm just grateful to clinch the 100 here," Djokovic said on court. "I had to work for it, that is for sure."

At this stage of his career, that effort may matter as much as the number itself.

